



WALLY SKALIJ Los Angeles Times

A FIRE RECOVERY PLAN

Los Angeles Unified School District is setting aside \$2.2 billion to rebuild campuses and make schools more resilient. Above, lunch boxes at Marquez Charter Elementary in Pacific Palisades. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Drones, cameras, metal detectors: New scrutiny for SoCal Edison

Utility faces more than 40 lawsuits from residents over cause of the Eaton fire.

By Salvador Hernandez

Amid drones, long-distance camera lenses and metal detectors, a hillside in Eaton Canyon has become the focus of intense scrutiny

over the last month by teams of private investigators now seeking clues on whether Southern California Edison equipment caused the massive fire that destroyed large swaths of Altadena.

Some of the findings and theories of these privately hired teams of fire investigators and electrical engineers have emerged in more than 40 lawsuits that residents have filed against the utility. Much of the focus has been

centered on a group of transmission towers where the first flames were seen just as the Eaton fire exploded.

Earlier this week, a new lawsuit alleged that an idle transmission tower on the hillside — one that has not been in use for more than 50 years — might have sparked the devastating blaze.

The stakes are high. With more than 9,000 homes lost and 17 people killed, liability is going to be a costly ques-

tion that could affect how Altadena is rebuilt.

Edison has been under scrutiny since the beginning, because residents who live in Eaton Canyon took photos and videos showing a fire burning under a transmission tower just as the blaze started.

Last week, Edison revealed that its lines over Eaton Canyon saw a momentary increase of electricity that could affect how Altadena is rebuilt. [See Edison, A10]

Needing aid, Newsom tries new strategy with Trump

After White House visit, the governor says he wants a fresh start to replace ‘noise.’

By Taryn Luna and Faith E. Pinho

WASHINGTON — Gov. Gavin Newsom’s official reason for visiting Washington this week was to shore up federal disaster aid in response to the Los Angeles County wildfires.

But the Democratic governor of California also had another objective: to continue to repair his rocky relationship with the commander in chief.

“There’s a familiarity, and there was a relationship that was born of a crisis around COVID,” Newsom said in an interview Thursday, adding that President Trump came through for California during the pandemic. “I wanted to go back to that space.”

The governor described his 90-minute sit-down with the president in the Oval Office on Wednesday as “a real and substantive” and “positive” conversation that included wildfire recovery and more thorny topics, such as water policy and the bills on Newsom’s desk to increase legal funding to challenge

the president’s actions in court.

Newsom’s expedition into the Republican White House shows the evolution of his approach to Trump: from a Democratic fighter and outspoken critic during a bruising election cycle to a statesman eager to move past the “noise” and forge a path to work together to benefit Californians.

“In a time of need and crisis, people need to see their representatives working together,” Newsom said. “I have no patience for people not working together in a crisis.”

As a top Democrat in a nation that elected Trump in November, crossing party lines and rebuilding a bond with the same guy who nicknamed him “Newsom” and previously blamed him for the wildfires could also help his political career if the governor has presidential ambitions of his own. The visit Wednesday appeared to be the president’s first meeting with any Democratic governor in his second term.

“This isn’t Newsom’s first rodeo and he recognizes this isn’t going to be his last disaster,” said Jack Pitney, a professor of politics at Claremont McKenna College. “If he’s going to be an effective governor, he has to keep lines of communication to [See Newsom, A7]

Immigrants in U.S. legally also fearful

Some of president’s executive orders aim to eliminate pathways to stay in the country.

By Andrea Castillo

WASHINGTON — Maria Eugenia Torres Ramirez never sought to reside in the United States illegally. A political activist from Venezuela who fiercely opposes President Nicolas Maduro, she approached border agents in Del Rio, Texas, in 2021 and asked for asylum, saying she

feared for her life.

Torres Ramirez, 37, fled Venezuela with her two young children after federal police fired shots outside her restaurant and began demanding that employees tell them where they could find her.

With her asylum case pending, Torres Ramirez, who now lives in Los Angeles, bolstered her legal armor by obtaining Temporary Protected Status, which allows people facing extraordinary conditions in their homelands to reside in the U.S. If denied asylum, [See Immigrants, A7]



MYUNG J. CHUN Los Angeles Times

MARIA Eugenia Torres Ramirez, a political activist, fled Venezuela in 2021 and sought asylum in the U.S.

Judge blocks plan to shed federal workers

Deadline is delayed in Elon Musk-led effort to pressure employees to resign.

By Chris Megerian, Collin Binkley and Byron Tau

WASHINGTON — A federal judge on Thursday temporarily blocked President Trump’s plan to push out federal workers by offering them financial incentives, the latest tumult for government employees already wrestling with upheaval from the new administration.

The ruling came hours before the midnight deadline for them to apply for the deferred resignation program, which was orchestrated by Trump advisor

Elon Musk.

Labor unions said the plan was illegal, and U.S. District Judge George O’Toole Jr. in Boston paused its implementation until after he could hear arguments from both sides at a court hearing scheduled for Monday afternoon. He directed the administration to extend the deadline until then.

White House Press Secretary Karoline Leavitt said 40,000 federal workers have already signed up to leave their jobs while being paid until Sept. 30. She described federal employees who have been working remotely as lazy, saying that “they don’t want to come into the office” and “if they want to rip the American people off, then they’re welcome to take this buyout and we’ll find highly qualified people” to replace them.

[See Employees, A6]

In Gaza, ‘my home has become a cemetery’

Woman and son keep vigil at house where kin are buried under rubble

By Bilal Shbair and Laura King

KHAN YUNIS, Gaza Strip — For Samar and Abdullah al-Farra, a Palestinian mother and son, a half-ruined house in the southern Gaza Strip is the only home they have.

It is also a tomb.

Like thousands of families all over Gaza, 38-year-old Samar and her 17-year-old son are trying to recover the remains of loved ones buried under rubble — an agonizing collective effort that has swiftly gathered pace since a truce was reached last month between Israel and the militant group Hamas.

Of their family of 13, Samar and Abdullah al-Farra were the only survivors of a trio of Israeli [See Gaza, A4]



BILAL SHBAIR For The Times

ABDULLAH AL-FARRA, 17, removes rubble while searching for the remains of four siblings. Airstrikes in 2023 killed six other siblings, his father and a cousin.

Trump to target ‘bias’ against Christians

President tells faithful after National Prayer Breakfast that a task force will aim to “bring God back.” **NATION, A5**

Interpreter for Ohtani sentenced

Ippei Mizuhara gets 57 months in federal prison for stealing \$17 million from Japanese baseball star. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

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NCAA adopts new trans policy

Decision limits competition in women’s sports to athletes who are assigned female at birth. **PERSPECTIVES, A2**

Championship or bust for Lakers

Team has built a title contender after shrewd trades, Dylan Hernandez writes. **SPORTS, B10**

Weather

Rain and drizzle. L.A. Basin: 63/48. **B6**



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